Understanding Homelessness ... Myths, Facts & Realities

Chico Campout for Compassion 2026 | November 14, 2026

SEE THE PEOPLE. LEARN THE FACTS. START A CONVERSATION.

You do not have to camp out to participate. Use this guide at home, in a classroom, or at a community gathering. Begin with a firsthand story. Then ask what evidence supports our beliefs about homelessness.

1. 'People choose to be homeless.'

Losing housing and refusing a particular shelter arrangement are not the same thing. Housing costs, available options, safety and family circumstances matter. Ask what workable housing alternatives really exist.

2. 'Everyone without housing has an addiction.'

People experiencing homelessness have diverse histories. Substance use and mental health conditions do not define everyone, and a person's appearance is not a diagnosis. Ask which reliable studies describe causes and pathways into homelessness.

3. 'Refusing a shelter bed means refusing help.'

Shelters can have restrictions or conditions that do not work for everyone, including pets, curfews, family arrangements, access, and safety. Ask what other options someone can choose.

4. 'Anyone with a job can afford housing.'

Employment and homelessness can overlap. Pay may not cover a local rental, and housing instability makes work routines difficult. Compare current Chico rents and wages before generalizing.

5. 'Most people here came from somewhere else.'

This requires local data, not anecdotes. Check the Butte County Point-in-Time count and relevant methodology; explain survey limits before claiming what the numbers mean.

6. 'Clearing an encampment ends homelessness.'

Moving a person or campsite changes visibility. It is not the same as obtaining a stable home. Ask how many people moved into permanent housing.

7. 'Homelessness only means sleeping in tents.'

Families, seniors, youth, workers, and people temporarily staying with others can face housing instability. Different programs count different populations. Explain definitions.

A 20-30 MINUTE DISCUSSION

SEE: Watch one vetted first-person interview or hear from a local guest. LEARN: Choose two assumptions and separate observation from evidence. DISCUSS: What surprised you, and what local facts still need verification? REFLECT: What is one assumption you will reconsider?

SOURCES AND LIMITS

Framework: Invisible People, Effective Homelessness Advocacy Messaging Toolkit (2025), especially pages 4, 17 and 30-34: https://invisiblepeople.tv/2025research/invisible-people-messaging-toolkit/

The toolkit's 2024 survey studied messages, not Chico homelessness prevalence. Use dated Butte County Continuum of Care and City of Chico primary sources for local statistics. This is an independent Chico educational adaptation, not an endorsement by Invisible People.

More resources: www.sfranzyshen.org/campout/understanding-homelessness/ | scotty@sfranzyshen.org